

YASIR IQBAL

THE NEXT 100

MUSIC

SOULFUL SOIRÉE

MEHTAB ALI NIAZI, 23

Sitarist, Delhi

"Mehtab is a brilliant musician. His music is a blessing for listeners"

–Pandit Gaurav Mazumdar, *Sitar maestro*

When Mehtab Ali Niazi performed at the Guru Purnima of Ustad Allah Rakha Khan Sahab in 2018, the tabla maestro Ustad Zakir Hussain said *Wah* and told him you are carving a different path. Mehtab felt he had arrived because there were stalwarts such as Pandit Shiv Kumar Sharma, Pandit Nayan Ghosh, Shivamani, Suresh Wadkar and others in the audience. Mehtab has music in his genes because his grandfather and father Mohsin Ali Khan too are musicians of the Bhendi Bazaar gharana. A child prodigy, he learnt the santoor first and started playing on stage at the age of 12. "I had no other option. I was carrying the legacy of six generations. But I don't consider it a burden," he says. His control of the instrument is perfect; his confidence in handling intricate note patterns uncanny and his note-changing ability amazingly swift. He makes the sitar sing. "I play the *gayaki* of Ustad Vilayat Khan sahib," he says. He practises for five hours daily and is learning vocal music from Pandit Sajan Mishra. Apart from playing classical music, he has also collaborated with Jazz musicians and ghazal singers. And he wants to be not only the most famous musician of the country but of the world as well. ■

– S. Sahaya Ranjit

NOTABLE NOTES When he played his first concert for Pandit Birju Maharaj's birthday, Maharaj Ji wanted to take a photograph with him